

Finding And Installing Elders

*A Process for Identifying, Developing, and Commissioning
Men to Lead*

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FINDING AND INSTALLING ELDERS

A PROCESS FOR IDENTIFYING, Developing, and
Commissioning Men to Lead
Pastors Connection Network
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Introduction: The Pipeline Problem

MOST CHURCHES DO NOT have an elder problem. They have a pipeline problem.

The reason elder teams are filled with men who were qualified by tenure rather than character, or with men who govern rather than shepherd, or with men who do not know what their role requires — is almost never that there are no better candidates in the congregation. It is that those better candidates were never identified, never invested in, never developed, and never given a path into the office.

Leadership development is perhaps the most neglected discipline in evangelical church culture. We preach about discipleship. We teach about spiritual formation. We talk about raising up the next generation. But when it comes to the specific, intentional, patient work of identifying men with elder potential and developing them toward that calling over several years — most churches have no process at all.

The result is predictable. When an elder position becomes

Paul's instruction to Titus is a direct response to this problem. "This is why I left you in Crete, so that you might put what remained into order, and appoint elders in every town as I directed you." The appointment of elders is not something that happens organically when the right men happen to emerge. It is an intentional act of pastoral leadership — something that is planned, pursued, and executed with care.

This book is a guide to that process. How to find the men who have the potential to become elders. How to invest in them over time in ways that develop the character and competency the office requires. How to evaluate them honestly before placing them in the role. How to involve the congregation in the process in ways that strengthen rather than complicate it. And how to install elders with the theological weight and communal significance the office deserves.

This is not a quick process. The timeline from identifying a potential elder to installing a qualified one is measured in years, not months. But every year you invest in this process is a year that builds toward the kind of elder team that will multiply your ministry, extend your pastoral coverage, and ensure that the flock is genuinely shepherded long after you are no longer the one doing the shepherding.

FINDING AND INSTALLING ELDERS

What you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men, who will be able to teach others also. — 2 Timothy 2:2

CHAPTER ONE

Why Elder Development Must Be Intentional

THE CASE AGAINST WAITING for leaders to appear

There is a pastoral fantasy that good leaders appear spontaneously. That if you preach faithfully, disciple consistently, and build a healthy culture, the men who need to lead the church will somehow surface when the time is right and be ready to assume responsibility when the office becomes available.

This fantasy is not entirely wrong. A healthy church culture does produce better leadership candidates than an unhealthy one, and faithful preaching does form the kind of character that elder ministry requires. But it does not happen automatically or reliably enough to build a leadership pipeline on. The pastoral fantasy of spontaneous leadership emergence has left too many churches scrambling for candidates, settling for less than they should, and installing men who were not ready.

The biblical pattern is deliberate. Paul instructs Titus to

THE COST OF PASSIVE LEADERSHIP DEVELOPMENT

WHEN CHURCHES ARE PASSIVE about developing leaders, several predictable problems emerge.

First, the leadership pool is limited to whoever happens to be visible. The men who end up being nominated are the men who hold other prominent roles in the church — the Sunday school teacher, the worship leader, the generous giver. This is a pool that is filtered by visibility rather than by the qualifications the office actually requires. And the men who have the character and gifts for elder ministry but who are not naturally self-promoting will rarely surface in this process.

Second, the men who are installed are often unprepared for the specific demands of the role. They know how to do the things that made them visible. They may not know how to shepherd a grieving family, confront a brother in sin, guard doctrinal integrity under pressure, or provide genuine accountability to the senior pastor. These are skills that must be developed — and they cannot be developed after installation. They must be in place before it.

Third, the culture of the elder team is shaped by whoever

THE FOUR STAGES OF AN ELDER DEVELOPMENT PIPELINE

A HEALTHY ELDER PIPELINE has four stages: identify, invest, include, and install. Each stage takes time, and each stage serves a specific purpose. Skipping any of them produces problems that manifest later.

Identify: The pastor and elder team are actively looking for men with elder potential. Not nominally — not in the vague sense of being open to nominations if someone happens to suggest one. Actively, with specific attention and specific criteria.

Invest: The men who have been identified are receiving intentional pastoral investment. They are being developed through reading, mentoring, honest conversation, and graduated experience. The elder team is not simply hoping they grow; it is actively contributing to their growth.

Include: The developing leaders are being given real ministry responsibility — not just nominal involvement, but genuine ownership of specific ministry areas, with the authority and accountability that real responsibility requires. They are being tested by experience before they are tested by evaluation.

Install: The men who have moved through the pipeline are being formally evaluated against the biblical qualifications

The timeline from identify to install is typically two to four years. That is not too long. That is the right length of time to ensure that the men being installed have been genuinely prepared for what the office requires.

THE VISION THAT DRIVES THE PIPELINE

ELDER DEVELOPMENT REQUIRES A long-term vision — a picture of what the elder team should look like five to ten years from now, and a commitment to building toward it deliberately rather than waiting for it to materialize accidentally.

What does that vision look like specifically? It is a team of men who genuinely know the congregation they serve — who have personal pastoral relationships with the families assigned to their care. It is a team with enough theological grounding that they can collectively guard the doctrinal health of the church, identify concerning trends, and address them with competence. It is a team diverse enough in gift, background, and personality to cover the range of pastoral needs the congregation presents. And it is a team that is continuously developing the next generation of leaders within its own pipeline, so that when a member leaves, retires, or is transitioned out, there is always someone ready to step into the role.

Building toward that vision is one of the most important investments a senior pastor can make. And it begins not with a selection committee but with a walk through the congregation — looking, asking, praying, noticing the men whose lives and gifts and character suggest the calling that a

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

How has your church historically developed elder candidates? Has the process been intentional or reactive?

Who are the men in your congregation right now who might have elder potential that has not been formally identified or developed? What has prevented them from being identified?

What would a five-year elder development vision look like for your specific church? What would you want to be true about your elder team five years from now that is not true today?

What is the biggest obstacle to building a more intentional elder development pipeline in your church? Is it cultural, structural, relational, or something else?

CHAPTER TWO

Identifying Elder Candidates

WHERE TO LOOK AND what you are looking for

The identification stage of elder development is often where the process gets stuck — because pastors are not sure what they are looking for, and because the men they should be looking at are often not the men who seem most obvious.

The most obvious candidates for eldership in most congregations are the men who already hold visible leadership roles: the Sunday school teacher, the small group leader, the prominent donor, the longtime deacon. Some of these men will indeed turn out to be elder candidates. But visibility in the congregation is not the same thing as readiness for the office, and a serious identification process will look beyond visibility to the specific character and gifts that the role actually requires.

What you are looking for, fundamentally, is a man who is already functioning in some respects as an elder even without the title. A man who naturally draws others to him for

WHERE TO LOOK FOR ELDER POTENTIAL

SMALL GROUPS AND COMMUNITY Life

The most reliable place to identify elder candidates is in the informal contexts of congregational community — small groups, ministry teams, and the ordinary social life of the church. In these settings, the qualities that distinguish an elder candidate from a regular member are most visible: who do people naturally turn to? Who handles conflict with grace? Who speaks into theological questions with clarity and humility? Who notices when someone in the group is struggling and takes responsibility for following up?

The pastor who is paying attention in these contexts will notice specific men whose natural patterns of behavior already resemble what elder ministry requires. These men are not always the most impressive. They are not always the most articulate. But they are already doing, informally and without title, what the elder is supposed to do. That is the strongest indicator of genuine calling.

Ministry and Service Contexts

How a man serves — particularly when serving is inconvenient, unacknowledged, or difficult — reveals a great deal about his character. The man who serves faithfully when no one is watching, who completes what he has committed to

Pastors who are intentionally looking for elder candidates will be watching ministry contexts with this in mind. Not just asking “Who is available to serve?” but “Who serves in a way that reveals the character we need in our elders?” These are sometimes the same men, but not always.

Seasons of Personal Difficulty

One of the most revealing windows into a man’s character is how he handles personal difficulty — loss, conflict, failure, illness, family struggle. The man who walks through genuine difficulty with faith, honesty, and resilience — who does not collapse, does not become bitter, does not handle his pain by inflicting it on others — is demonstrating a kind of tested character that is invaluable in elder ministry.

Elder ministry is full of difficulty. The elder who has never been tested does not know how he will respond when he is. The man who has been through significant hardship and emerged with his faith and his relationships intact has demonstrated something that no evaluation form can generate: genuineness.

THE INITIAL CONVERSATION

WHEN A MAN HAS been identified as a potential elder candidate, the next step is a conversation. Not a nomination, not a formal process, not a public announcement. Just a conversation.

The purpose of this conversation is twofold. First, it is an invitation to explore: “I want you to know that I see elder

Second, it is a genuine inquiry into the man's own sense of calling: "Do you have any sense that God might be calling you toward this kind of leadership? What draws you toward it? What concerns you about it?" The man who aspires to the office of overseer desires a noble task — but the aspiration should come from genuine calling, not from ambition or the desire for status.

This conversation is not a commitment. It is an opening. The pastor is saying: "I see something in you. Let's talk about it." The response to that opening will tell you a great deal about whether the man is ready to begin a more intentional development process.

WHAT YOU ARE NOT LOOKING FOR

IT IS WORTH BEING explicit about what should not drive the identification process, because the wrong motivations are common.

You are not looking primarily for people who want to be elders. Desire for the office is not irrelevant — Paul says it is a noble aspiration — but it is not sufficient. Some men who want to be elders want the title more than the work. The identification process must be driven by character observation, not by ambition.

You are not looking for the most impressive people. Impressive people are not always the most qualified. The most impressive person in your congregation may be

You are not looking for people who will confirm your own instincts and preferences. A healthy elder team includes men who will disagree with you in constructive ways, who will catch things you miss, who will speak into your blind spots. The identification process must be driven by the team's needs, not by the pastor's comfort.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Who in your congregation is already functioning informally as an elder — caring for others, speaking into theological questions, demonstrating the character the office requires? Have you told them what you see?

Where in your congregation's life are you most likely to observe the character qualities that distinguish elder candidates? Are you paying attention in those contexts?

What biases drive your identification process? Are you drawn primarily to the most visible, the most impressive, or the most familiar? How would you know?

Who would benefit from hearing that you see elder potential in them, regardless of whether the formal process is ready to begin?

CHAPTER THREE

Developing Elder Candidates

THE INVESTMENT THAT TURNS potential into readiness

Identifying a man with elder potential is the beginning of a process, not the end of one. The gap between “This man has what it takes” and “This man is ready to be installed” is real, significant, and must be intentionally closed through a sustained period of development.

Development is not the same as preparation for an evaluation. It is not a crash course in what elders do before a formal assessment. It is a multi-year investment in the growth of a man’s character, theological depth, relational skill, and pastoral instincts — an investment that makes him genuinely more capable of the work the office requires, not merely more aware of what is expected of him.

The difference matters. A man who has been prepared for an evaluation knows how to answer the questions. A man who has been genuinely developed has internalized what the questions are asking and can demonstrate the answer in his

THEOLOGICAL FORMATION

THE MOST FOUNDATIONAL DIMENSION of elder development is theological. The “able to teach” qualification requires a man with genuine depth of biblical knowledge and doctrinal clarity. That depth does not come from a weekend seminar. It comes from years of serious engagement with Scripture and the theological tradition.

A meaningful elder development process includes a theological reading plan — a curated list of books that develop the candidate’s understanding of systematic theology, biblical theology, hermeneutics, church history, and pastoral theology. This is not an academic curriculum. It is a formation curriculum, designed not to make the candidate a theologian but to give him the theological foundations that confident, stable, doctrinally grounded elder ministry requires.

Suggested Reading Categories: Systematic theology (a solid introductory text), biblical theology (a Christ-centered survey of Scripture), a church history survey, a pastoral theology text, and a book specifically on elder ministry. Supplement with monthly theological articles or a subscription to a journal that your pastor recommends.

Beyond reading, theological development requires conversation. The developing elder needs opportunities to discuss what he is reading, to have his questions engaged seriously, to work through the theological tensions that his reading is surfacing. The regular meeting between the

THE MENTORING RELATIONSHIP

THE HEART OF ELDER development is the mentoring relationship. A more mature pastor or elder is investing personal time and attention in the developing leader — not as a program, but as a genuine pastoral investment in a person.

What does this relationship involve? It involves meeting regularly — monthly at minimum, more frequently if possible. It involves honest conversation about the candidate's life: his marriage, his spiritual disciplines, his struggles, his growth. It involves the mentor sharing from his own experience — not just what he knows but what he has learned, what he has gotten wrong, what he would do differently. And it involves graduated challenge: the mentor is consistently moving the candidate toward the next level of responsibility and the next level of honest self-examination.

The mentoring relationship is also the primary context for character feedback. The developing elder needs to hear honest, specific, caring feedback about his character patterns — the places where he is genuinely growing and the places where real work remains. This kind of feedback is most effective when it comes within a relationship of genuine trust and genuine care. It cannot be delivered by a formal evaluation form and received well. It must be delivered by a person who the candidate knows genuinely loves him.

The Feedback Conversation

One of the most important skills in elder development —

Effective feedback in this context is specific rather than general (“I noticed in the small group last week that when Mark challenged your interpretation, you became visibly defensive and shut down the conversation” rather than “You sometimes seem defensive”). It is curious rather than accusatory (“I’ve noticed this pattern and I’m wondering what’s behind it” rather than “You have a defensiveness problem”). And it is hopeful rather than merely corrective (“This is an area where I really believe you can grow, and I want to help you do it”).

The developing elder who receives this kind of feedback and responds to it with genuine humility rather than defensiveness or capitulation is demonstrating exactly the character quality that elder ministry requires. The one who cannot receive honest feedback about himself will not be able to deliver honest feedback to others.

GRADUATED RESPONSIBILITY: LEARNING BY DOING

THEORETICAL DEVELOPMENT — READING, mentoring, conversation — must be accompanied by practical experience. The developing elder needs to be doing elder-like things before he becomes an elder, so that his installation is not his first exposure to the actual work of the role.

At the earliest stage, the developing elder is shadowing. He is accompanying the pastor or an elder on pastoral visits, counseling situations, hospital calls, and difficult conversations. He is not leading. He is observing and processing — learning by watching someone with more experience navigate the actual situations that elder ministry presents.

At the next stage, he is leading under supervision. He is taking primary responsibility for specific pastoral care situations — a small group, a set of families he is caring for, a particular ministry he is overseeing — with the mentor available for debrief and guidance but not doing the work for him.

At the final stage before formal installation, he is operating with substantial independence. He is doing the work of an elder in all but formal title, with the elder team providing accountability and support but not directing his every move. This stage is the most revealing — it shows what the man actually does with real responsibility, rather than what he says he will do with hypothetical responsibility.

WHEN A DEVELOPING LEADER STALLS

NOT EVERY MAN WHO is identified as a potential elder candidate will progress through the development pipeline to installation. Some men will reach a stage of development and stop — because the work reveals character limitations they were not willing to address, or because life circumstances make the additional responsibility genuinely inadvisable, or because the

These are not failures. They are the process working as intended.

The mentor's responsibility when a developing leader stalls is to name it honestly and caringly. "I've noticed that our process seems to have stalled, and I want to understand what's happening. Let's talk honestly about where you are and where you're headed." This conversation sometimes surfaces what has been preventing progress — a struggle that needs to be addressed, a question of calling that needs to be resolved, a relationship difficulty that has been unacknowledged. And sometimes it confirms that this particular man is not, at this time, on a trajectory toward eldership.

In either case, the honest conversation is more valuable than continued ambiguity. And the relationship in which it happens, if it has been built with genuine care, is robust enough to survive it.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What theological formation resources are you currently providing to potential elder candidates? Is the process intentional enough to actually develop theological depth, or is it informal and incomplete?

Do your current mentoring relationships with developing leaders include the kind of honest, specific, caring character feedback that genuine development requires? What prevents it?

Where in your congregation do candidates have opportunities for graduated responsibility — to do elder-like work before they carry the elder title?

CHAPTER FOUR

The Formal Assessment Process

MOVING FROM DEVELOPMENT TO discernment

At some point in the development process, the question moves from “Is this man growing?” to “Is this man ready?” The formal assessment process is the structure that answers that question with enough rigor and breadth to make a confident, responsible decision.

The assessment is not the beginning of the discernment process. By the time a candidate enters formal assessment, a great deal of discernment should already have happened through the development relationship. The formal assessment confirms, surfaces anything that has been missed, and creates a documented process that protects both the candidate and the church.

What the assessment should not be is a perfunctory interview that signals to the candidate that the decision has already been made. Even if the elder team has high confidence in a candidate, the assessment process should be

THE SELF-ASSESSMENT TOOL

THE ASSESSMENT BEGINS WITH the candidate. A written self-assessment tool — one that walks him through each of the 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 qualifications with specific, honest questions — serves several purposes.

It forces engagement. The candidate who has to write down his honest answers to specific questions about his marriage, his self-control, his theological clarity, and his reputation in the community has gone somewhere different than the candidate who answers them verbally in a conversational setting. Writing requires a different kind of honesty.

It surfaces concerns early. The self-assessment often surfaces areas of genuine concern that the candidate would not volunteer in a conversational assessment. Not because candidates are deceptive — usually they are not — but because the written format creates space for honest reflection that the social dynamics of a face-to-face evaluation can suppress.

It demonstrates the candidate's self-knowledge. How a candidate describes himself in the self-assessment — with what level of specificity, with what degree of honest acknowledgment of his limitations, with what quality of reflection — is itself a data point about his character and maturity.

A good self-assessment tool is not a legal document. It is a

THE SPOUSE CONVERSATION

THE SPOUSE CONVERSATION HAS been mentioned in previous chapters, but in the context of the formal assessment process it deserves more detailed treatment.

The conversation should be conducted by someone who has a genuine relationship with the spouse — not a stranger, not a purely institutional representative. Ideally, it is conducted by the senior pastor's spouse, or by an elder's wife, or by someone the spouse trusts to hold the conversation with both honesty and care.

The setting matters. This is not a formal interview in a meeting room. It is a conversation over coffee, in a home, in a context that feels personal rather than institutional. The difference in the quality of information that flows from these two settings is significant.

The key questions have been outlined in previous chapters, but they are worth restating here with some additional context. “How does your husband lead in the home?” — this is the household management qualification, assessed by the person who sees it most clearly. “How does he handle conflict between the two of you?” — this is the self-control, gentleness, and not-quarrelsome qualifications, assessed by the person he is most likely to conflict with. “Is there anything about his personal life, his health, his struggles, or his patterns that you believe the elder team should know?” — this is the open question that gives the

The spouse conversation will occasionally surface something that changes the assessment entirely. More often it confirms what the process has already found. In either case, it is non-negotiable. The church that assesses elder candidates without speaking to their wives has left the most important evaluator out of the process.

THE ELDER TEAM ASSESSMENT CONVERSATION

THE FULL ELDER TEAM’S evaluation of the candidate is the core of the formal assessment. This should be a structured conversation — not a casual chat, but a deliberate and thorough examination of what the team knows about the candidate against the biblical qualifications.

The structure should ensure that every qualification is specifically considered. Not “Does anyone have any concerns?” — a question that almost always produces silence regardless of what is actually present. But: “Let’s go through the qualifications one by one. What positive evidence do we have that this man meets this standard? What concerns do we have? What would we want to know more about?”

This structure does several things. It ensures that no qualification is skipped because it was assumed or because no one wanted to raise it. It surfaces positive evidence that might otherwise go unstated — specific observations from specific contexts that build the team’s confidence. And it creates space for concerns to be raised without requiring the person raising them to feel like they are attacking a popular

The assessment conversation should also include a discussion of fit. Not just “Does this man meet the qualifications?” but “Does this man’s specific gifts and character add something the team currently lacks? Is his temperament compatible with the team’s current dynamics? Is this the right time for him to join the team?” These are legitimate questions, and the team should be free to consider them.

THE DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT

A DEDICATED CONVERSATION ABOUT theology and doctrine should be part of every elder assessment process. The candidate and one or more members of the elder team (typically the senior pastor) meet specifically to discuss what the candidate believes and why.

This conversation should cover the following at minimum: the candidate’s understanding of the gospel (both the content of the good news and the meaning of faith and repentance), his understanding of the authority and sufficiency of Scripture, the church’s specific doctrinal positions that every elder will be expected to defend, and the candidate’s approach to theological disagreement — how does he distinguish between convictions to be defended and differences to be accommodated?

The tone should be conversational and curious, not adversarial. The goal is not to catch the candidate in a theological error but to understand how he thinks, what he has studied, and how he handles the pressure of a theological challenge. A man who engages the conversation with confidence, humility, and genuine curiosity about where the

The doctrinal assessment also serves a formation function. The conversation itself often deepens the candidate's theological engagement — he encounters questions he had not considered, surfaces uncertainties he had not previously named, and leaves with a clearer picture of where his theological formation still needs work. Even when the assessment results in a “not yet,” the doctrinal conversation has served the candidate well.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What does your current elder assessment process actually look like? Does it include all four components described in this chapter, or does it skip some?

How thoroughly does your assessment process examine each individual qualification? Is it systematic enough to ensure that no qualification is assumed rather than assessed?

What happened the last time the spouse conversation surfaced something unexpected? How did the process handle it?

What would you do if the doctrinal assessment revealed that a candidate you expected to affirm has significant theological gaps? Do you have a “not yet” pathway that is genuinely developmental rather than simply a rejection?

CHAPTER FIVE

Presenting to the Congregation

THE CONGREGATION'S ROLE IN affirming its leaders

The congregation's role in the elder installation process is one of the most theologically significant and most practically neglected dimensions of a healthy elder pipeline. In many churches, the congregation's involvement consists of a brief announcement from the pulpit and a perfunctory vote. In others, there is no formal involvement at all — the elder team makes its decision, and the congregation is informed.

Both of these approaches undervalue something important: the congregation's genuine knowledge of the candidate and the congregation's genuine stake in who exercises authority over its spiritual life.

The New Testament picture of congregational involvement in elder selection is not entirely clear, but there are strong indications that the early church expected the congregation to play a meaningful role. Acts 6 describes the congregation selecting the first deacons from among themselves. Acts 14

WHAT CONGREGATIONAL INVOLVEMENT IS NOT

CONGREGATIONAL INVOLVEMENT IN ELDER selection is not a democratic election in which the most popular candidate wins. Popularity is not a qualification for eldership, and a process that gives the congregation veto power over any candidate it does not prefer produces elder teams shaped by congregational preference rather than by biblical qualification.

It is also not a forum for the expression of personal grievances. A congregational period of affirmation is not an opportunity for members who have unresolved conflicts with the candidate to relitigate them in a public setting. The appropriate channel for genuine concerns is the elder team's formal assessment process, not a congregational meeting.

And it is not a rubber stamp on a decision already fully made. When congregational input is invited purely as a formality — when it is clear that the elder team will proceed regardless of what the congregation says — the congregation quickly learns that their involvement is performative rather than real. That lesson erodes trust and congregational investment in the process over time.

MEANINGFUL CONGREGATIONAL INVOLVEMENT IN

elder affirmation is an informed, structured opportunity for the congregation to share what they know about the candidate — both positive and concerning — before the final decision is made.

The structure typically involves a period of formal candidacy during which the candidate's name, basic biographical information, and a statement of faith are shared with the congregation. The congregation is invited to share any significant concerns about the candidate's character or fitness for the office with a designated member of the elder team, within a defined time frame.

The key word is “significant.” The invitation is not for general opinions about the candidate's suitability — it is for specific information about his character, his reputation, or his behavior that the elder team may not have been aware of in its assessment. This framing focuses the input and reduces the likelihood of the process being used as a vehicle for preference expression rather than genuine discernment.

COMMUNICATING THE CANDIDATE WELL

THE WAY THE CANDIDATE is presented to the congregation before the affirmation period shapes what the congregation understands they are being asked to affirm. A bare announcement with minimal information produces minimal engagement. A thoughtful presentation that helps the congregation understand who this person is, what the elder office requires, and why this person has been judged to meet those requirements produces a more invested and more meaningful affirmation.

Presenting the candidate well is also an act of theological formation for the congregation. It teaches them what eldership is and what it requires. It demonstrates that the elder team takes the qualifications seriously. And it models the kind of deliberate, thoughtful discernment that the congregation can expect from their leadership in other contexts.

HANDLING CONCERNS THAT ARE RAISED

WHEN CONCERNS ARE RAISED during the congregational affirmation period, the elder team's response will determine whether the process is trusted. A concern that is received, genuinely investigated, and either addressed or explained will build trust. A concern that is dismissed, minimized, or ignored will erode it.

Not every concern raised deserves the same level of investigation. Some concerns reflect genuine information about the candidate's character that the process had not yet surfaced. These must be taken seriously, regardless of who is raising them or how inconvenient they are. Other concerns reflect personal preference, unresolved conflict, or factional opposition rather than genuine questions about fitness for the office. These require a different kind of pastoral response — not dismissal, but honest engagement with the underlying issue.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What role does your congregation currently play in the elder affirmation process? Is it meaningful or perfunctory?

How does your church communicate elder candidates to the congregation? Does the presentation reflect the theological significance of the office?

What process exists for the congregation to raise concerns during a candidacy period? Is it accessible, confidential, and genuinely engaged?

Have you ever had a congregational concern surface something the assessment process had missed? How was it handled, and what did it teach you?

CHAPTER SIX

The Installation Service

INSTALLING ELDERS WITH THE weight the office deserves

The installation of an elder is one of the most significant acts in the life of a local church. A man is being set apart for a specific, holy calling. He is being formally recognized as one whose character and gifts have been tested and found sufficient for the work of shepherding the flock of God. The congregation is making a commitment to follow his leadership and support his ministry. And the elders are making a commitment to hold one another accountable to the calling they share.

Given the significance of all of this, it is remarkable how casually most churches conduct the installation of their elders. A brief mention from the pulpit. A vote by show of hands. A handshake from the senior pastor. And the man is an elder.

This casualness communicates something. It communicates that the office is not that serious. That the bar for holding it is not that high. That the congregation's

A meaningful installation service communicates the opposite. It says: this man has been tested, and he has been found faithful. This office carries genuine weight, and we are taking seriously the responsibility of placing him in it. The congregation is committing to pray for him, to follow his leadership, and to hold him accountable to the calling he is assuming. And he is committing, before God and this community, to shepherd the flock entrusted to his care with the character and the faithfulness that the Chief Shepherd requires.

THE THEOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE OF INSTALLATION

THE NEW TESTAMENT DESCRIBES two primary elements in the installation of church leaders: the laying on of hands and the charge from the community.

The laying on of hands appears in multiple New Testament contexts: in the commissioning of the first deacons in Acts 6, in the commissioning of Paul and Barnabas for their missionary journey in Acts 13, and in Paul's instruction to Timothy about laying hands on elders in 1 Timothy 5:22. The gesture is not magical. It does not confer the gifts that are being recognized — those were already present before the installation. But it is a solemn, embodied act of recognition and blessing — the community saying, through the physical medium of human touch: we see what God has done in this man, and we are setting him apart for this specific calling.

The charge is the verbal dimension of the installation. It is

DESIGNING A MEANINGFUL INSTALLATION SERVICE

THE INSTALLATION SERVICE DOES not need to be elaborate. But it should be intentional. The following elements form the core of a meaningful installation:

A Scripture reading that frames the office — Acts 20:28–32, 1 Peter 5:1–4, or Titus 1:5–9 are natural choices.

A brief description of the process through which this man was assessed — not lengthy, but enough to communicate that the process was serious and that the congregation can have confidence in the result.

A charge to the elder being installed — delivered by the senior pastor or lead elder, drawing on Scripture, naming the specific calling, and asking the man to respond publicly with a commitment.

A charge to the congregation — calling the congregation to pray for their elder, to follow his leadership, and to hold him accountable to the calling he is assuming.

The laying on of hands — by the existing elder team, as a solemn recognition of the man's calling and a blessing on his ministry.

Corporate prayer — the congregation praying together for the man being installed, for the whole elder team, and for the congregation they serve together.

AFTER INSTALLATION: ONBOARDING AND ONGOING DEVELOPMENT

THE INSTALLATION IS NOT the end of the process — it is a significant milestone within a continuing one. The newly installed elder needs to be intentionally onboarded into the culture and practice of the existing elder team. Not just briefed on the logistics of meetings and responsibilities, but genuinely welcomed into the relational and spiritual culture that the team has built.

This means introducing the new elder to the congregation members he will be specifically responsible for caring for. It means including him in the elder team's devotional and relational life, not just its institutional functions. It means pairing him with a more experienced elder for the first year — someone who can mentor him in the specific relational and pastoral challenges that elder ministry presents.

It also means maintaining the expectation of ongoing development. The installation is not a graduation. It is a commissioning. The elder who was in development before installation should continue to be in development after it — growing theologically, growing pastorally, growing in his ability to care for the specific people entrusted to him.

And the elder team should build into its annual rhythm a meaningful evaluation of how each elder is doing — not a performance review in the institutional sense, but an honest, caring conversation about how he is growing, where he is

EVALUATING THE PIPELINE ITSELF

ANNUALLY, THE ELDER TEAM should evaluate not just how individual elders are doing but how the pipeline itself is functioning. Are there men currently in the identify stage? The invest stage? The include stage? Is the distribution healthy — is the team building toward future capacity rather than simply maintaining current levels? Are there any gaps — demographic, gift-based, or contextual — in the current elder team that the pipeline should be specifically developing toward?

These questions are not bureaucratic. They are pastoral. The health of the elder pipeline is the health of the future congregation. A team that thinks carefully about its succession is a team that loves the congregation it will eventually hand to someone else.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What would a meaningful, appropriately weighty installation service look like in your specific context? What would need to change about how you currently conduct installations?

How is the newly installed elder being onboarded into the relational and spiritual culture of the team, not just the institutional logistics of the role?

What ongoing development expectations exist for your current elders? Is the expectation of growth maintained after

FINDING AND INSTALLING ELDERS

When did you last evaluate the elder pipeline itself? How many men are currently in each stage, and is the pipeline healthy enough to sustain the team's long-term needs?

Conclusion: The Work That Will Outlast You

THERE IS A KIND of pastoral legacy that is built primarily through visible ministry — through memorable sermons, well-attended events, programs that bear fruit, buildings that are built. This is not nothing. But it is fragile. Programs end. Buildings deteriorate. The congregation that was built around one man's gifts and energy is vulnerable the moment that man is no longer there.

There is another kind of pastoral legacy that is built through people. Through the men who were identified, invested in, developed, assessed, installed, and sent into a lifetime of faithful shepherd ministry. Through the elder teams that carry the mission of the church forward long after the pastor who built them has moved on. Through the congregations that were shaped by elders who actually shepherded, actually taught, actually prayed, actually knew their sheep by name.

The pastor who builds a healthy elder pipeline is not just caring for the congregation he currently serves. He is investing in the congregation's next fifty years. He is building the structure that will sustain the mission when he is no longer the one leading it. He is doing the most important leadership work that a pastor can do — and because it is largely invisible, largely slow, and largely uncelebrated, it is also the work that is most easily neglected.

Do not neglect it.

The sheep need shepherds. The church needs elders who will actually function as the New Testament describes. And those men will not appear spontaneously. They must be found, developed, tested, installed, and sustained in the work.

That is the work this book has been pointing toward. Begin it. Be patient with it. Trust the God who called you to it to work through it.

And watch what he builds.

For this is why I left you in Crete, so that you might put what remained into order, and appoint elders in every town as I directed you. — Titus 1:5

Appendix: Tools for the Elder Pipeline

A. THE ELDER CANDIDATE Self-Assessment

The following questions are designed to help an elder candidate engage honestly with the 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 qualifications. Complete this in writing before your first formal assessment conversation.

Above Reproach: Is there any current pattern in my life that, if known by the congregation, would provide legitimate grounds for questioning my fitness for this office? If so, what is it, and how am I addressing it?

Husband of One Wife: How would I honestly describe the quality and health of my marriage? What does my wife say about how I lead and care for our home?

Household Management: How do I lead in my home? What would my children say about the character of my father? Where are the genuine strengths and weaknesses of my household leadership?

Self-Control: Are there areas of appetite, temper, or

Sober-Minded: How do I handle anxiety, uncertainty, and pressure? Do I provide stability to those around me, or do my emotional responses add to their stress?

Able to Teach: Can I clearly explain the gospel? Can I articulate the core doctrines of the Christian faith in my own words? Can I identify and respond to teaching that is doctrinally concerning?

Not a Lover of Money: What does my relationship with money look like? How do I make financial decisions? What would those who know me financially say about my integrity?

Outside Reputation: What do my neighbors, colleagues, and community contacts think of me? Is there any dimension of my life outside the church that the elder team should know about?

Personal Growth: Where am I currently growing most significantly? Where is the work that still needs to be done?

B. A Sample Installation Charge

[Name], you have been examined by this elder team according to the qualifications the Holy Spirit has given in 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1, and you have been found to meet them. You have been presented to this congregation, and they have affirmed your calling to this office.

Today you are being installed as an elder of [Church Name]. This is not a title. It is a calling. And the calling carries weight.

You are called to shepherd the flock of God that is among us — to know the sheep, to feed them from the Word, to protect them from false teaching, to visit them in illness, to comfort them in grief, to confront them in sin when love

You are called to be an example to the flock — not merely a decision-maker, but a model. What your life looks like will teach this congregation what the Christian life looks like. Take that seriously.

You are called to serve alongside your brother elders in the shared work of shepherding this congregation. Support them. Pray for them. Speak honestly to them. Build with them.

And you are called to do all of this not under compulsion but willingly, not for shameful gain but eagerly, not as one who dominates but as one who serves — because the Chief Shepherd is watching, and he will give the crown of glory to those who are faithful in this calling.

[Name], do you accept this calling and commit to fulfill it faithfully, with God's help?

(Candidate responds: I do, with God's help.)

Then receive the laying on of hands as a sign of this congregation's recognition of your calling and their blessing on your ministry.